

investigation UNIDENTIFIED BODIES

MURDER ON THE TRACKS

The rising number of unidentified bodies found on the rail tracks in Punjab and Haryana leads police to believe these were not accidental deaths but cold-blooded killings

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

When, in April 2006, Bharti Arora took over as the Superintendent of Police of the Government Railway Police (GRP) at Ambala, she was struck by an unusually high number of inquest reports into the bodies recovered from the 1,500-km long railway tracks in Haryana. In 2006 alone, the GRP personnel found 1,568 bodies—147 more than the previous year. Last year, the body count rose to an all-time high of 1,696, signalling a grotesque trend of a daily average of five deaths on the tracks across the state. Even more startling has been the fact that a large number of the victims remain unidentified. Of 10,178 such bodies recovered since 2001 in Haryana, as many as 3,290—roughly one-third—were cremated without identification.

While accidents and suicides are the common reasons given for such deaths, police officials are now discerning a sinister dimension in the mounting number of unidentified bodies—many of them could well be cases of murder passed off as accidents. "It's an alarming trend," says Inspector General of Haryana GPR K.K. Mishra. "There are good reasons to suspect that a number of unidentified bodies are cases of murder in which the killers go scot-free," he says. Such suspicion is not without basis: only last year, 20 of the unidentified bodies found on the rail tracks had turned out to be cases of cold-blooded murder wherein the dead were thrown before speeding trains.

Curiously, the figures of such casualties in the neighbouring Punjab are no less shocking—

as many as 2,331 unidentified bodies have been found along the state's 7,000-km railway track since 2003. Investigations into the rising number of deaths on the tracks in Punjab and Haryana have not only revealed the appalling safety standards of the Indian Railways, but have also shed light on official callousness in solving the murders, most of which were labelled as accident cases. "Dumping the murdered victim on a busy rail track or into a canal is the best way of disposing off a body," says a GRP official.

Most of the murdered victims have been traced as the natives of Haryana, but GRP officials also darkly hint at the rising incidents of crime against the migrants due to subterranean social tensions in Punjab and Haryana. An increasing number of migrants from Bihar and Uttar Pradesh are now settling in both the rich agrarian states and are taking agricultural land on rent for cultivation, an arrangement which sometimes runs into bloody disputes. Going by its hunch that many of the bodies recovered were those of migrant labourers, the Haryana GRP launched Operation Pehchan in Bihar last month to identify the bodies found on the state's rail tracks and were cremated in the recent past. Based on the premise that most of the unidentified victims resembled labourers from Bihar or Uttar Pradesh, the drive—entailing display of the victims' faces on flex boards and their belongings including blood-stained clothes—initially focussed on five major railway stations—Patna, Muzaffarpur, Katihar, Chhapra and Bhagalpur, the areas which send large number of labour-

ESCAPE ROUTE:
The criminals are able to invariably cover their tracks because of official callousness

of the bodies found since 2003 in Punjab have not been identified

5 bodies on an average, are found daily on rail tracks in Punjab

171 have been labelled as murder cases in Haryana since 2003